AUTHOR’S NOTE

I have heard of no one who, after interacting with Ratan Tata, has returned unimpressed; many feel awestruck by the encounter. It was certainly no different for me when I met him for the first time on a Monday morning in the latter part of 1994, at Udyog Bhavan, which housed the Union industry ministry. He had come to call on the minister whose private secretary I was. On that day, I was only expecting to meet just another industrialist like the many I regularly met during the Licence Raj regime that was still largely intact.

To my surprise, when Ratan appeared, he did not have the visage traditionally associated with industrialists. He was immaculately dressed in a blue suit, probably a Brioni suit—the fact that he prefers the Italian brand, amongst the most expensive in the world, was only a recent discovery for me—and a white shirt and a blue polka-dotted tie. Standing at over six feet and charming, with sharp hazel eyes that he inherited from his father and that meld the colours of green, gold and brown, he could easily have been mistaken for a model.

And when he spoke, I was in for another surprise. With a deep voice and a calmness that was at once impressive, he imparted life to Arthur Schopenhauer’s famous words: ‘Politeness is to human nature what warmth is to wax.’

I had not heard of him much until then since, during my college days and later, the Tata who really mattered was J.R.D. Tata, an industrialist who eclipsed all others and to crown it, had been awarded the Bharat Ratna just two years before I first met Ratan. My father too was a fan of JRD, and he never tired of saying that the senior Tata had a striking aristocratic look with his prominent Parsi nose accentuating it.

After that, I met Ratan professionally on many occasions. My interactions with him were more frequent in the finance ministry where his opinions, expressed in individual meetings or as a member of the group of captains of industry, were keenly awaited and valued. And every time I met him, my admiration for him gained newer heights.

It was, however, in Rashtrapati Bhavan in March 2017 that I got the opportunity to spend hours upon hours, socially, for as long as I chose, with